Far Niente

OAKVILLE
The Spirit of Cabernet

BY MARYANN WOROBIEC

The Oakville AVA is sacred ground for Cabernet Sauvignon. Its vineyards are considered the filet mignon of the valley because of how the grape performs in the *terroir*. Oakville Cabernets are beloved for their richness and density of fruit, savory and earth elements combined with their reputation as being among the most ageworthy in Napa Valley.

Located between Yountville and Rutherford as you head north, Oakville can appear to visitors as little more than a blip, with the famed Oakville Grocery serving as its spiritual center. Yet Oakville boasts the highest concentration of benchmark estates in Napa Valley—Harlan Estate, Robert Mondavi, Opus One, Silver Oak, Far Niente and Heitz Cellar to name a few. It is also home to two of California's most renowned vineyards, To Kalon and Martha's.

The Oakville Grocery dates to 1881 and is one the longest continuously operating grocery stores in California. It remains both a must-stop for tourists and a convenient pit stop along Highway 29 for the locals. Visitors can refuel with excellent coffee, pastries and high-quality picnic provisions, including hearty sandwiches and a curated selection of gourmet pantry goods. On sunny days, guests enjoy wood-fired pizzas on the patio. The shop also offers an excellent selection of gifts for food lovers.

Grapegrowing in Oakville began with H.W. Crabb, an Ohio native who came to California in search of gold. Crabb purchased 240 acres in what is now Oakville in 1868. He built a railroad depot and initially planted table and raisin grapes. In 1872, Crabb established a vineyard and winery he named To Kalon, Greek for "highest beauty." At the time, it was one of the largest vineyards in the region, producing about 5,500 cases of wine annually.

Since Crabb's death, vintners have debated the vineyard's legacy. Subsequent owners divided and sold the land. In 1966, vintner Robert Mondavi built his winery on part of the To Kalon property, helping to launch Napa's modern wine era. Along the way, Mondavi was granted trademarks in 1988 and 1994, now owned by Constellation Brands following their purchase of the Mondavi winery in 2004. Other vintners argue that they have the right to use the name because they farm portions of the original estate; grower Andy Beckstoffer was able to secure naming rights for his portion. The dispute continues and has grown bitter at times, a testament to To Kalon's enduring significance.

Driving through Oakville offers one of the best ways to understand the "valley." The AVA covers ground from the foothills of the Vaca mountain range's volcanic soils on its eastern flank to the Mayacamas' alluvial soils on its western edge, with each side offering distinct characteristics in their wines.

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WHERE TO TASTE

Cardinale Winery

7600 St. Helena Highway | cardinale.com

It's a short drive off of Highway 29 up to the beautiful stone building where Cardinale hosts its tastings, but it feels like a world away from the traffic and bustle of the valley floor. Panoramic views are highlighted by a recent upgrade, with more outdoor options, comfortable seating and stylish designs. Tasting experiences of Christopher Carpenter's Bordeaux-style wines include culinary options and library vintages.

Cardinale

Far Niente Winery / Bella Union Winery

1350 Acacia Drive | farniente.com

Gil and Beth Nickel opened Far Niente in 1979, and the 19th-century stone winery and surrounding fairy tale-esque gardens are definitely worth a visit to experience the environs, fine wines and a chance to try their late-harvest Dolce.

We also recommend taking a short drive north to check out the latest tasting room in the winery's portfolio, Bella Union (which is technically in Rutherford), founded in 2012 as a way to celebrate regional blend expressions of Napa wine. The former Provenance tasting room was recently remodeled for Bella Union, and embraces the La Belle Époque era with more modern designs, many tasting opportunities and stunning views.

Rudd

Nickel & Nickel

8164 St. Helena Highway | farniente.com/wineries/nickel-and-nickel

A distinctive white estate fence outlines this picturesque estate, which includes an 1884 Victorian farmhouse, barn-style winery and horse stables. The wines are also distinctive; winemaker Joe Harden dives into single-vineyard expressions of Napa Cabernet Sauvignon through a variety of methods that make an excellent case for *terroir*.

Rudd Estate / Crossroads House

500 Oakville Cross Road | ruddwines.com

Rudd Estate is among the most scenic wineries in Napa, with a wonderful garden and scraggly oak trees creating a serene setting. It's also among one of the few second-generation, family-owned properties you can visit. While visiting Rudd to taste their wines is an excellent idea, the Crossroads House is also on the property, where their second label of the same name is served with various offerings from caviar to picnic lunches curated by nearby Under-Study.

B Cellars Winery

703 Oakville Cross Road

bcellars.com

Groth Vineyards & Winery

750 Oakville Cross Road

grothwines.com

Miner Family Winery

7850 Silverado Trail

minerwines.com

Opus One

1144 Oakville Cross Road

opusonewinery.com

PlumpJack Estate Winery

620 Oakville Cross Road

plumpjackwinery.com

Promontory Wine

1601 Oakville Grade

promontory.wine

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WHERE TO EAT

Brix

7377 St. Helena Highway | brix.com

Brix represents farm-to-table cuisine, but in this case the restaurant is located amid the farm. Part of an exquisite 16-acre estate, there are raised beds of vegetables and herbs, a fruit and citrus orchard and a vineyard where the Kelleher family–owners of Brix and their own namesake winery–grow grapes. Seasonal offerings might include pappardelle with bone marrow, black pepper and Parmigiano-Reggiano, or their fried chicken, which is served with a cheddar biscuit, mashed potatoes and gravy. Further comfort food items, like "Arnold Palmer's Meatloaf" are perfectly prepared, as is a Dungeness crab tagliatelle with crispy prosciutto and sea urchin butter.

Mustards Grill

7399 St. Helena Highway | mustardsgrill.com

"Sorry, everything is delicious," you'll see on the signage for Mustard's Grill, a dreamy restaurant that is always buzzing with excitement and dishing up hearty American fare as imagined by chef-owner Cindy Pawlcyn. Since 1983, Pawlcyn has helped define wine country cuisine–seasonal, fresh, comforting and approachable, and of course, a terrific match for wine. The delicate onion rings are a must-order, as is the Mongolian pork chop with sweet-n-sour red cabbage and house-made mustard. The kitchen does lighter fare with plenty of precision, including the daily tostada and Hunan grilled chicken salad.

shooting Mustards

Mustards

Oakville Grocery

Breakfast/ Coffee/ Sandwiches/ Snacks

Oakville Grocery

7856 St. Helena Highway | oakville-grocery.com

Do stop by the iconic Oakville Grocery, if only to stretch your legs and wander among the crowded shelves packed with gourmet pantry ingredients and snacks that make excellent gifts. Coffee, pastries, cookies and picnic provisions are all here, as well as gourmet salads and large, shareable sandwiches, like the "Wagon Wheel" sandwich with Fra'mani rosemary ham, Cowgirl Creamery Wagon Wheel Cheese and Dijonnaise. Wood-fired pizzas, served on the patio, are also top notch.

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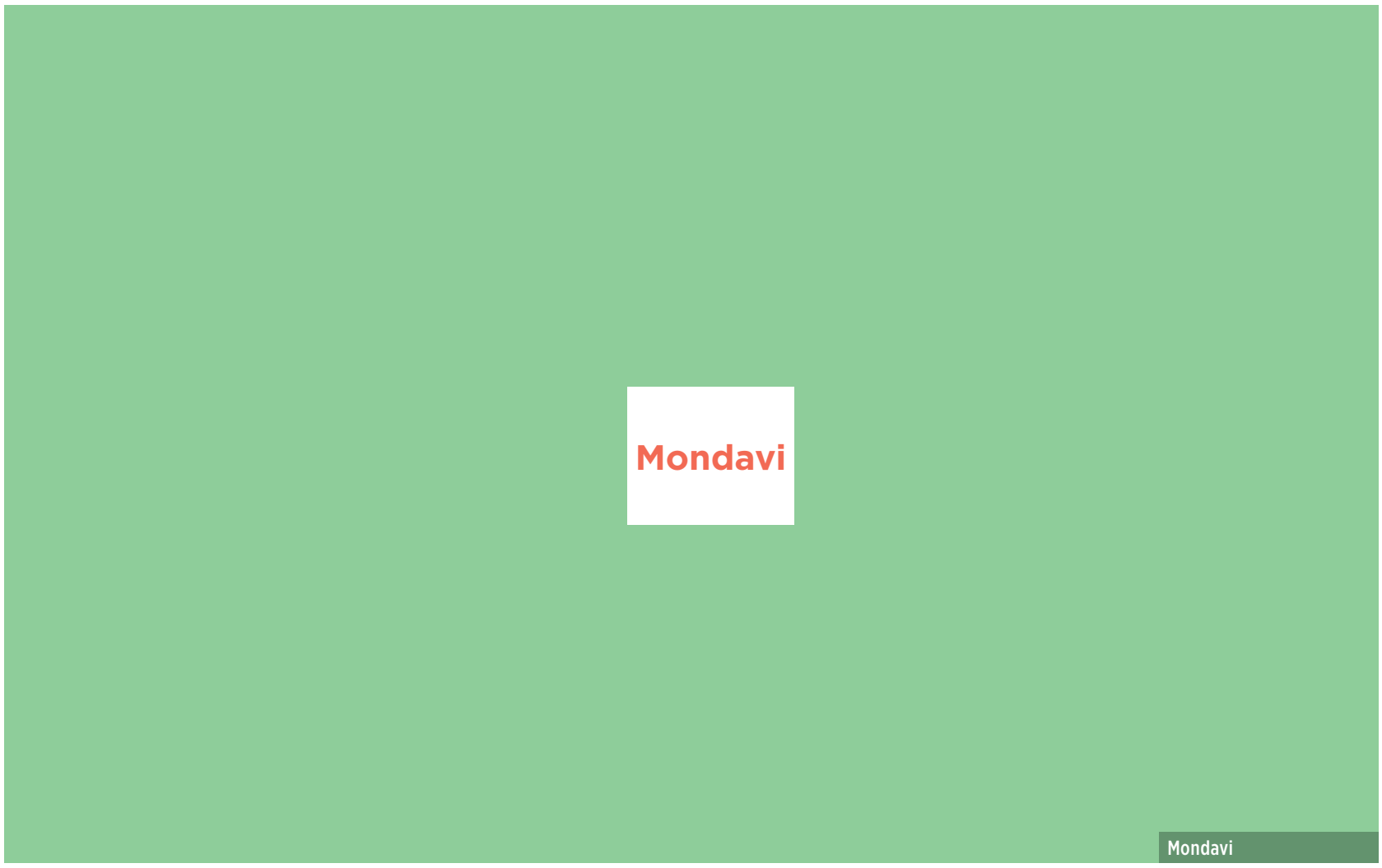


Mondavi

AN OAKVILLE ADVENTURE *from MaryAnn Worobiec*

THE EVERYTHING OLD IS NEW AGAIN TOUR

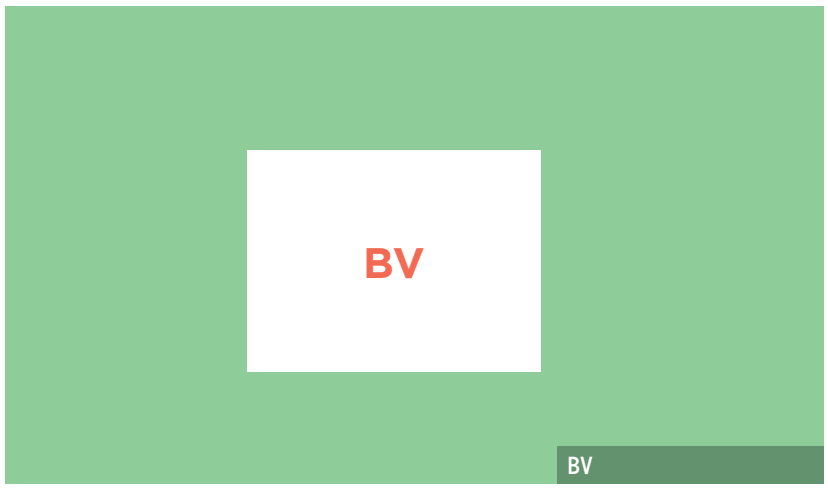
Two of the most anticipated re-openings this year are the **Robert Mondavi Winery** and **Beaulieu Vineyard**. Both are scheduled to open soon; RMW in May and BV by July, and they are offering reservations as of press time.

When historic wineries reinvent themselves they reflect broader shifts across Napa Valley. As a new generation of owners and wine lovers shapes the region's future, Napa continues to ask: How do you honor a storied past while embracing what comes next?

At RMW, the renovation preserves the iconic 1966 Cliff May design, including the signature arch and tower that echo California's Spanish missions. The team has added new structures on either side, including a hospitality wing wrapped in glass walls that bring guests visually closer to the vineyards. Designers lined the ceiling with oak staves salvaged from old fermentation vats—wine stains and all—adding texture and authenticity to the modern space.

Five minutes down the road, BV has also chosen restoration over replacement. The team reinforced the original stone walls instead of rebuilding them and repurposed redwood from old tanks to clad the ceilings, even preserving boards marked with handwritten notes. During construction, the winery recycled 98% of its materials. The redesigned space blends contemporary elements and natural light with the historic stone facade, creating a seamless indoor-outdoor flow. Historical artifacts are on display Throughout the property, including founder Georges de Latour's refurbished Cadillac near the entrance.

Expect heavier traffic as wine lovers line up to experience the results of these years-long renovations. As with any highly anticipated restaurant debut, allow a little time for staff to settle into the new spaces and refine service. Even so, both re-openings promise to reward the wait.



BV

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